FIRST AID BASICS

What to do in the first minutes, until help arrives. Read it now; take a class to really learn it.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: Basic first-aid information, **not a substitute for hands-on training or medical care.** Take a certified first-aid and CPR course (American Red Cross, American Heart Association or similar), and renew it every two years. **In an emergency, call 911 first.**

1. FIRST: CHECK, CALL, CARE

CHECK

Is the scene safe for you? Traffic, fire, wires, water, an angry dog. Don't become a second victim. Then check the person: are they awake? Breathing?

CALL

Call **911** (or have someone call) for anything serious. Say where you are first. Stay on the line: dispatchers can coach you through CPR and more.

CARE

Give the care you're trained for. Wear gloves if you have them. Keep the person still and warm, and reassure them until help arrives.

2. LIFE THREATS FIRST

EMERGENCY	WHAT TO DO	KNOW THIS
Not breathing / no pulse (adult)	Call 911 and get an AED. **Push hard and fast** in the center of the chest: at least 2 inches deep, 100 to 120 times a minute. Don't stop until help takes over or an AED tells you to.	Hands-only CPR works for adults who suddenly collapse. Trained? Add 2 breaths after every 30 pushes. AEDs talk you through every step.
Severe bleeding	Press hard and directly on the wound with a cloth or gauze, and keep pressing. If blood soaks through, add more on top. For a limb, if pressure doesn't stop it, apply a tourniquet **2 to 3 inches above the wound** (not on a joint) and tighten until bleeding stops.	Note the time the tourniquet went on. Don't remove it; let medical staff do that. Learn more: Stop the Bleed (stopthebleed.org).
Choking (adult or child over 1)	If they can't cough, speak or breathe: stand behind them and give quick, upward **abdominal thrusts** just above the navel. The Red Cross teaches 5 back blows, then 5 thrusts, repeated.	If they can cough forcefully, let them keep coughing. If they become unresponsive, start CPR. Infants under 1 need a different method: take a class.
Severe allergic reaction	Swelling of face, lips or throat; trouble breathing; hives; dizziness. Use their **epinephrine auto-injector** in the outer thigh. Call 911.	Follow the injector's instructions; a second dose may be needed if there's no improvement. Go to the hospital even if they feel better.
Heart attack	Chest pain or pressure; pain in arm, back, neck, jaw or stomach; short of breath; cold sweat; nausea; light-headed. Call 911. Keep them resting.	Women more often have nausea, back or jaw pain. Give aspirin only if the 911 dispatcher tells you to.
Stroke	**BE FAST:** Balance loss, Eyes (vision change), Face drooping, Arm weakness, Speech trouble, Time to call 911.	Note the time symptoms started. Treatment works best fast.

3. COMMON INJURIES AND ILLNESSES

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO	GET HELP IF
Cuts and scrapes	Press to stop bleeding. Rinse with clean water. Apply antibiotic ointment and a bandage. Change daily.	Deep, gaping, dirty or from an animal bite; won't stop bleeding; red, warm, swollen or pus (infection). Ask about a tetanus shot.
Burns	Cool under cool running water for at least 10 minutes. Remove rings. Cover loosely. No ice or butter; don't break blisters.	Large or deep; face, hands, feet, groin or joints; electrical or chemical. *(TR-01)*
Sprains and strains	Rest it. Ice wrapped in a cloth, 20 minutes at a time. Wrap snugly (not tight). Raise it above the heart.	Can't bear weight; looks deformed; numb; very swollen.
Possible broken bone	Keep it still in the position you found it. Splint only if you must move the person. Ice wrapped in cloth.	Always. Call 911 for head, neck, back, hip or thigh injuries, and don't move the person.
Nosebleed	Sit up and lean **forward**. Pinch the soft part of the nose for 10 to 15 minutes without letting go.	Lasts more than 20 minutes, or after a head injury.
Shock	Pale, cold, clammy skin; fast breathing; weakness; confusion. Lay them flat, keep them warm, and don't give food or drink.	Always: call 911.
Seizure	Clear the area and protect the head. Don't hold them down or put anything in the mouth. Time it. Afterward, roll them onto their side.	Over 5 minutes, repeated, first seizure, injury, pregnancy, or trouble breathing.
Low blood sugar (diabetes)	Shaky, sweaty, confused. If they can swallow: about 15 grams of fast sugar (4 oz juice or regular soda, or glucose tablets). Recheck in 15 minutes.	Not improving, can't swallow, or unresponsive: call 911.
Poisoning	Call **Poison Help: 1-800-222-1222** (free, 24 hours). Have the container in hand.	Unresponsive, seizure or trouble breathing: call 911.
Heat and cold	See the Severe Weather Reference *(TL-05)* and Shelter & Staying Warm *(TR-03)*.	

4. FIRST-AID KIT

Buy a complete kit or build one. Keep one at home, one in each car, a small one in each go-bag. Check it every 6 months.

- ☐ Adhesive bandages, assorted sizes (25 or more)
- ☐ Sterile gauze pads (3x3 and 4x4 inch) and 2 large trauma dressings
- ☐ Roller bandages (3 and 4 inch) and adhesive tape
- ☐ Elastic wrap bandage; 2 triangular bandages
- ☐ Tourniquet (a commercial windlass type)
- ☐ Antiseptic wipes; antibiotic ointment; hydrocortisone cream
- ☐ Instant cold packs
- ☐ Non-latex gloves (several pairs); CPR breathing barrier
- ☐ Scissors, tweezers, safety pins
- ☐ Thermometer
- ☐ Emergency (foil) blanket
- ☐ Pain relievers, antihistamine, anti-diarrhea medicine, aspirin (for adults)
- ☐ Personal medications and the Medical Information Sheet *(DC-04)*
- ☐ A first-aid manual

5. TRAINING RECORD

NAME	COURSE (FIRST AID / CPR / AED / STOP THE BLEED)	DATE	RENEW BY

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. American Red Cross: First Aid Steps; Make a First Aid Kit; Choking. redcross.org/take-a-class
2. American Heart Association: Hands-Only CPR; Warning Signs of a Heart Attack; Stroke Warning Signs. heart.org stroke.org
3. American College of Surgeons: Stop the Bleed. stopthebleed.org
4. America's Poison Centers: Poison Help line 1-800-222-1222. poisonhelp.org
5. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Seizure First Aid; Diabetes: Low Blood Sugar. cdc.gov

IMPORTANT: First-aid recommendations are updated every few years. Training gives you the hands-on practice this sheet cannot. This document reflects the sources above as of November 2026.